

EYEWITNESS July 30, 1864

The **Battle** of the **Crater**

During the siege of Petersburg, Colonel Henry Pleasants and his coal-mining troops (the 48th Pennsylvania) laid a mine beneath the Confederate lines. The explosion produced an enormous crater, burying hundreds of Rebel troops in debris. But the Union advantage turned into catastrophe as Confederates had time to counterattack, and many Union soldiers became fatally trapped in the crater.

“I was lying on the ground resting my head on my hand and thinking of the probable result, when the denouement came. I shall never forget the terrible and magnificent sight. The earth around us trembled and heaved so violently that I was lifted to my feet. Then the earth along the enemy’s lines opened, and fire and smoke shot upward seventy-five or one hundred feet. The air was filled with earth, cannon, caissons, sand-bags and living men, and with everything else within the exploded fort ... Our orders were to charge immediately after the explosion, but the effect produced by the falling of earth and the fragments sent heavenward that appeared to be coming right down upon us, caused the first line to waver and fall back, and the situation was one to demoralize most troops.”

BREVET MAJOR CHARLES H. HOUGHTON, 14TH NEW YORK HEAVY ARTILLERY, FROM *BATTLES AND LEADERS OF THE CIVIL WAR*, 1888

“Little did these men anticipate what they would see upon arriving there: an enormous hole in the ground about 30 feet deep, 60 feet wide, and 170 feet long, filled with dust, great blocks of clay, guns, broken carriages, projecting timbers, and men buried in various ways—some up to their necks, others to their waists, and some with only their feet and legs protruding from the earth ...

The whole scene of the explosion struck every one dumb with astonishment as we arrived at the crest of the debris. It was impossible for the troops of the Second Brigade to move forward in line ... Before the